A BOOM CORE STARTER ADVENTURE

The Hollow Crown

Three sessions • Three or four heroes • One Core Master • Levels 1 to 3

The king rode out to seal a broken core. Thirty days later, his son still sings the song that was meant to bring him home.

BOOM

BEYOND OUR OWN MAXIMUM

Running This Adventure

The Hollow Crown teaches Boom to new players while telling a complete story. Each act is one session of three to four hours. Act 1 teaches the rules with nothing deadly on the table. Act 2 sends the heroes into a dungeon of traps, a puzzle, and real fights. Act 3 ends with a boss fight that kills a hero, a resurrection, and a reveal the heroes have to carry home.

What You Need

- The **Boom Core Guidelines**. This adventure points to its chapters instead of repeating rules.
- The **Boom Dice app** for rolls, loot boxes, the party stash, the shop, and the monster tab. Pick **The Hollow Crown** under **One-shots** in the CM tab, and every monster, fight, and loot box below is one tap away.
- Three or four players and one Core Master (CM).
- A copy of the **Lullaby handout** (Appendix B) to give the players in Act 1.

Adventure Background (CM Only)

Thirty days ago, **King Aldren of Brightmere** rode to the **Sunken Reliquary**, an old vault beneath the marsh where his ancestors locked away a cracked Divine soul core. The core had begun to leak, and Aldren went to seal it with his own hands. He took his guard captain, Varek, and a squad of soldiers.

The core did not want to be sealed. It poured into the king and hollowed him out. Aldren still lives, but the man is buried under the thing the core made of him: **the Hollow King**. His soldiers fell to the same rot. Before the core took him completely, Aldren sealed the inner vault with the only key he knew would never be forgotten: the lullaby he sang to his son every night.

Prince Corwin rules as regent. He does not know what his father has become. He only knows the king is missing, and that the song his father sang is the last thing he has of him.

Adventure Overview

Act	Session goal	Hero level
1. Commoners of Brightmere	Learn checks, combat, loot, and the market safely. Level up and train a first ability. Hook: find the king.	1 to 2
2. The Sunken Reliquary	Traps, the Hall of Six Seals puzzle, three fights, and a mini-boss.	2
3. The Hollow Crown	Boss fight. One hero dies, the boss escapes, a resurrection scroll is found, and the truth goes home to the prince.	2 to 3

Before the First Session

> **Tell your players: heroes can die**
>
> This adventure includes a fight where a hero dies and is brought back. You do not need to say when or who. Say it once at the start: *"In this story, heroes can fall and heroes can die. Death is not the end of your character here."* Players who know the stakes enjoy the danger. Players who are surprised by it feel cheated. (Safety Tools in Chapter 8 of the Core Guidelines are worth a minute before you start, too.)

Leveling: this adventure works with either leveling choice (Chapter 2). With the **XP bar**, the heroes level by eating the cores they're handed. With **Milestones**, level the party where the text says *Milestone*.

Scaling: every fight lists numbers for three and four heroes. With five or more, add one minion per extra hero.

Calendar: the world has four seasons of 100 days each, with no weeks or months. The adventure begins on **Day 71 of Autumn**, the Harvest Festival.

Act 1: Commoners of Brightmere

Session 1 • Level 1 to 2 • 3 to 4 hours

Brightmere is a walled river town of farmers, millers, and a small royal keep. Today is the Harvest Festival. The heroes are ordinary people: a stable hand, a baker's apprentice, a dockworker, whatever the players like. Nobody has stat points or abilities yet. That is the point: by the end of tonight they will.

Scene	Time	Teaches
1. Festival Morning	20 min	Characters, HP, the daily spirit coin roll
2. The Six Booths	45 min	Stat checks, difficulty, group rolls, ties
3. Rats in the Granary	45 min	Initiative, actions, armor, loot boxes
4. The Prince's Summons	30 min	Soul cores, leveling up, the first boom
5. Market and Trainer	45 min	The market, gear slots, ability tokens, building an ability
6. The Wounded Guard	15 min	The hook

Scene 1: Festival Morning

Read aloud

Brightmere wakes to drums. Banners of wheat-gold and ember-red hang from every window, and the smell of honey bread drifts up from the square. Today the harvest is in, and for one day nobody has to work. Nobody, that is, except you. You still need coin, and the festival is full of it.

Have each player name their commoner and say what they did for work before today. Every hero is **level 1** with **5 HP**, no stat points, and no abilities.

Then have everyone make their **daily spirit coin roll**: one d6 that does not explode, because they have 0 points in Spirit/Luck. That is how many Common spirit coins they start with.

Rules Spotlight: Commoners Don't Boom

With 0 points in a stat, you roll a single d6 that never explodes. Tell the players: *"Right now your dice are ordinary, just like you. Once you have a point in a stat, those dice can explode. You'll get there tonight."* This sets up the first big boom in Scene 4.

Scene 2: The Six Booths

Six festival booths line the square. Each booth is a check for one stat. Let the heroes wander and try whichever they like. Every hero has 0 points, so they roll 1d6 with no explosions. Use the Easy target of **2** for most booths so the players win and learn. A win pays **1d6 Common coins** (no explosions). A loss still pays 1 coin and a laugh.

Booth	Stat	Target	What happens
Tug-of-War Rope	Strength	2	Pull the miller's sons into the mud pit.
The Riddle Tent	Intellect	2	Old Mags asks: *"What has six sides and no corners in its luck?"* (A die.) Roll if they don't know.
Greased Piglet Chase	Speed	4	Medium. Catch the piglet before it reaches the well.
Haggler's Row	Charm	2	Talk a vendor down on a honey bread. Winner also gets the bread.
The Dunk Tank	Constitution	2	Sit on the plank and take the cold water without shouting.
Lucky Barrel	Spirit/Luck	2	Reach into a barrel of straw for a prize ribbon.

Finish with a **group roll**: the festival's three-legged race. The group chooses one hero to roll Speed, target 4. If they win, every hero gets 2 coins. Point out that there is one roll, no rerolls, and no helping.

Ties: if two heroes race the piglet and tie, nobody rerolls. Someone concedes. The first to concede is *the bigger person* and doubles their next roll (Ties, Chapter 5). Expect the whole table to concede at once. Let it happen.

> **Rules Spotlight: Stat Checks**
>
> Roll one d6 for every point you have in the stat. Meet or beat the target. With 0 points you roll a single d6 that does not explode. The CM sets targets with the Easy, Medium, and Hard chart in Chapter 5 of the Core Guidelines. If no stat fits, roll Spirit/Luck.

Scene 3: Rats in the Granary

> **Read aloud**
>
> *A scream cuts through the music. The granary keeper bursts out of the big stone barn, waving a broom. "Rats! Rats the size of dogs, in the festival grain!" Behind him, something heavy knocks over a barrel, and a dozen small eyes glint in the dark.*

This is a safe first fight. The rats are weak, they flee when hurt, and no commoner can die here.

Heroes	Rats
3	3 Granary Rats
4	4 Granary Rats

Granary Rat

Level 1 Minion • Common • Common tier

HP	3
Armor	0
Initiative	d20 + 0
Actions	1
Bite	1d4 (starter override: level 1 monsters hit for 1d6 (one hand), and even that can kill a commoner, so these rats bite softer)

A rat reduced to 1 HP, or left alone when its friends fall, runs into the walls and is gone. Rats don't swarm: they're too busy fighting each other over the grain. Roll each rat on its own.

Safe Fight Rule: Bruised

For this scene only, a commoner who drops to 0 HP is **Bruised** instead of dead. They are out of the fight, and they stand up with 1 HP when it ends. Tell the players this is a training wheel: *"Outside this barn, a commoner at 0 HP dies."*

Rules Spotlight: Your First Fight

Initiative: everyone rolls d20 + Speed, highest goes first. You can hold your turn until later in the round. **Your turn:** move up to 5 + level + Speed steps, and take 1 action: attack, use an ability, or interact with an object. **Unarmed:** a punch is one hand, 1d6 touch. A thrown rock is one hand, 1d4 ranged. **Armor:** subtract the target's armor from the damage. The rats have none.

Loot

Each hero opens a T1 loot box from one rat (monster level 1). Walk the players through the d100 in the app: a 1 booms into two more dice, 2-21 is coins, 22-35 a sellable reagent, 36-50 a healing potion, 51-70 an ability token, 71-99 an item (weapon, armor, jewelry, or gem by range), and any even roll also drops a soul core. Any cores they find here are extra; they can save them for the trainer in Scene 5.

Loot box: Each hero opens one T1 Common box from a level 1 monster (Granary Rat). In the app: One-shots, then **Make box**.

Scene 4: The Prince's Summons

Read aloud

The rats are gone and the square is cheering for you when the keep's bell rings three times. A herald in red pushes through the crowd. "You there. The ones who cleared the granary. His Highness, Prince Corwin, asks for you. Now."

The heroes are led up to the keep's small hall. **Prince Corwin** is barely twenty, tired, and trying to look older. The king's chair beside him is empty.

Read aloud

"Thirty days ago my father, King Aldren, rode to the Sunken Reliquary with Captain Varek and ten soldiers. Not one of them has come back. My lords say to wait. I am done waiting. I can't send an army into a marsh, but I can send people who just showed this whole town they don't run from things in the dark."

He sets a heavy chest on the table and opens it. Soul cores glow inside, faint and warm, beside a row of bronze tokens.

"Consider this good faith. The crown's cores, to make you more than you were this morning. And a token each, for the guild trainer. Bring my father home."

Each hero receives **11 level-1 soul cores** and **one ability token**: ten cores for the XP bar, and one to pay the trainer in Scene 5. (Add them from the stash or each sheet in the app.)

Leveling Up at the Table

XP bar: have every hero eat 10 cores now. Ten cores of your own level fill the bar, so each hero reaches level 2. **Milestone:** this is your first milestone. Level the whole party to 2, and keep one core each for the trainer.

- Spend 1 stat point on any stat.
- New HP is 5 × (level + Constitution). A level 2 hero has 10 HP, or 15 with a point in Constitution.
- Movement is now 5 + 2 + Speed steps.

The first boom: ask every hero to roll the stat they just put a point in. For the first time, a 1 explodes. Someone will boom. Make a big deal of it. That's the moment the game is named for.

Rules Spotlight: Soul Cores and Levels

With the XP bar, a core of your level fills 1/10 of the bar, and ten of them take you up one level. A core above your level fills the rest of the bar, but never more than one level. If you drop below 1 HP at level 2 or higher, you lose a level instead of dying, your XP bar empties, and you lose a stat point and anything you can't hold at the lower level.

The Lullaby

As the heroes turn to leave, Corwin stops them. He is quiet for a moment.

Read aloud

"When I was small, I was afraid of the dark. My father sang me the same song every night. He told me if I was ever lost, I should follow the song home. I don't know why I'm telling you this." He hums a few bars, then sings it softly, all the way through.

Read the lullaby aloud (Appendix B), then hand the players the Lullaby handout. In the app, the handout creator in the CM tab can turn it into a note for the whole party. Do not explain why. It is the key to the Hall of Six Seals in Act 2, and it is the clue that breaks their hearts in Act 3.

Scene 5: Market and Trainer

The Market

Open the market (the **Market** button in the CM tab). The heroes have festival coins, loot box coins, and maybe reagents to sell. They can buy from the Core and Fantasy shops in the app's **Shop**. A few favorites, in Common coins:

Item	Price	What it does
Dagger or sword	2 or 8	1d6 touch, one hand. Physical, no plus.
Spear or greatsword	5 or 15	2d6 touch, two hands.
Sling or longbow	1 or 12	1d4 or 2d4 ranged. Ammo refills from storage.
Wooden shield or leather armor	6 or 10	1 physical armor; takes an armor slot.
Warded robe	15	1 magical armor; takes an armor slot.
T1 healing potion	10	Drink as an action: heal 1d6 (it can boom).
Rope, lantern and oil, rations	2, 5, 1	Useful in a dungeon.

Each hero can equip up to 2 weapons, 2 armor, and 2 magic items. Reagents sell for the number on them, and loot items sell for a d100 roll of coins of their tier (which can boom). Cores sell only if you allow it; we suggest not here, because the trainer wants them. Close the market when shopping is done, and keep it short.

Mother Hesk, Guild Trainer

> **Read aloud**
>
> *The trainer's hall smells of chalk and lamp oil. Mother Hesk is ancient, half blind, and missing two fingers. "The prince's tokens," she says, weighing one in her palm. "Good bronze. Sit. Tell me what you want to become."*

Each hero spends their token and one level 1 core on a new T1 ability (Learning Abilities, Chapter 4). Walk them through the four steps of Building an Ability in Chapter 4 of the Core Guidelines:

- **Pick a tier.** Always T1 for a new ability: 1d6, 1 target, 1 round, 1 effect.
- **Pick a stat.** The CM chooses which stat fits; that stat's points add to the roll.
- **Choose the roll's job.** Damage, healing, or temporary HP.
- **Choose one effect.** A condition, a move, a boost or drain, or a utility effect.

Players who freeze can pick a sample: Spark Dart (Intellect, damage and Burning) or Adrenaline Shot (Constitution, heal and Blessed), or one of these:

Sample T1 ability	Stat	What it does
Shield Shove	Strength	1d6 damage to one target and push them 1 step.

Sample T1 ability	Stat	What it does
Quick Feet	Speed	1d6 temporary HP to yourself; you are not Slowed this round.
Sharp Word	Charm	1d6 damage to one target and make them Frightened for 1 round.
Lucky Charm	Spirit/Luck	Heal one ally 1d6 and Bless them for 1 round.

Tips: a hero who tips Hesk a few coins and roleplays well earns her favor. Note it. A trainer who likes you will teach better things later.

> **Rules Spotlight: Ability Slots**
>
> A level 2 hero has 3 ability slots. Abilities are learned at T1 and trained up one tier at a time, each step costing a token and a core of the new tier. If you lose a level and have more abilities than slots, you lose one at random.

Scene 6: The Wounded Guard

> **Read aloud**
>
> *Evening falls. Lanterns are lit along the river, and the festival is winding down when the north gate horn blows, one long broken note. A soldier in the king's red staggers through the gate. His armor is split. His skin around the wound is gray, like old ash, and it is spreading.*
>
> *He grabs the nearest of you by the collar and presses a folded, muddy map into your hands. "The Reliquary. The king... the king is still down there. But he isn't... he isn't the king." His eyes roll back, and he goes still.*

The soldier, **Pell**, is alive but unconscious. The town healer takes him. The map shows the old causeway into the marsh and the Reliquary entrance. Corwin offers a cart and driver at first light. End the session here.

Act 2: The Sunken Reliquary

Session 2 • Level 2 • 3 to 4 hours

The Reliquary is a flooded stone vault under the Graymire marsh. The heroes go room by room. Every room has a clue, a choice, or a fight. Each room that is cleared or solved drops a **T1 loot box into the party stash** unless the room says otherwise, which teaches the party to share.

Area	Time	What's there
The Causeway	15 min	Travel and a group roll
1. Entry Hall	20 min	Tripwire dart trap
2. The Barracks	45 min	Fight: corrupted soldiers
3. Flooded Gallery	25 min	Swinging blade hazard
4. Hall of Six Seals	40 min	The lullaby puzzle
5. Shrine Spring	15 min	Rest and the party stash
6. Captain's Post	45 min	Mini-boss: Captain Varek

The Causeway

> **Read aloud**
> *The cart leaves you where the road gives up and the marsh begins. An old stone causeway runs out into gray water and fog, toward a squat stone dome half sunk in the reeds. Halfway there, the causeway is gone: a gap of black water, and a fallen log that might reach.*

Group roll: the party chooses one hero to roll Strength to drag the log across, or Speed to leap it and tie a line. Use the Medium target for that hero's points. **Failure:** the crossing takes hours, the party arrives at dusk, and one extra Hollow Recruit waits in the Barracks.

Area 1: Entry Hall

> **Read aloud**
> *The dome's door hangs open on one hinge. Inside, a round hall of carved stone, its walls covered in tiny holes in neat rows. A soldier in the king's red lies face-down near the far arch, three thin darts in his back. A thread glints at ankle height just past him.*

Clue: the holes, the dead soldier, and the thread. A hero who says they are looking can spot it with an Easy Intellect or Spirit/Luck check.

Trap: Tripwire Darts (T1). A hero who crosses carelessly triggers it. They make a Speed check (Medium) to dodge. On a failure, roll 1d6 damage, minus armor. Stepping over the thread, cutting it, or jamming the holes avoids it completely.

Rules Spotlight: Traps

Always give a clue first. A trap is built like an ability: its tier sets the dice, targets, and effects. A check avoids it. If it catches more than one hero, roll its dice once and everyone who failed takes that total, minus their own armor. (Traps and Hazards, Chapter 9.)

Search: the dead soldier carries 2d6 Common coins and a note: *"Captain says the king is just tired. Captain is lying."*

Loot box: Into the party stash: T1 Common box from a level 1 monster (Entry Hall). In the app: One-shots, then **Make box**.

Area 2: The Barracks

Read aloud

Bunks line the walls of a long room lit by a guttering lamp. Soldiers in royal red stand among them, still as statues. Then they turn, all at once, and you see their faces: gray as ash, eyes like dull coals. On every breastplate is the king's crest.

Heroes	Enemies
3	Corrupted Soldier, Hollow Recruit
4	Corrupted Soldier, 2 Hollow Recruits

Corrupted Soldier

Level 2 Standard • Common • Common tier

Stats	Strength 1
HP	10
Armor	0
Initiative	d20 + 0
Actions	1
Melee	2d6 + 1 (spear, two hands)
Ranged	2d4 (thrown javelins)

Abilities

Crest Strike (signature, T1, Strength): 1d6 + 1 damage to one target, who is Bleeding for 1 round (1 damage at the start of their turn).

Hollow Recruit

Level 2 Minion • Common • Common tier

HP	5
Armor	0
Initiative	d20 + 0
Actions	1
Melee	2d6
Ranged	2d4

Two or more Hollow Recruits swarm: one initiative and one pooled attack roll (One Roll, Many Targets, Chapter 3).

Tactics: the soldiers fight in silence and never flee. Every few rounds one mutters a single word: *"Majesty."*

Loot: each hero opens their own T1 box from one level 2 enemy. A Crest Strike token can drop from the Soldier's box.

Loot box: Each hero opens one T1 Common box from a level 2 monster (Barracks). In the app: One-shots, then **Make box**.

Area 3: Flooded Gallery

Read aloud

The floor slopes down into knee-deep black water. A long gallery of pillars stretches ahead, each pillar scored with deep, fresh gouges at chest height. Somewhere above, in the dark, something heavy creaks back and forth on a chain.

Clue: the gouges and the creaking. The water halves movement.

Hazard: The Pendulum (T2). A great blade sweeps the middle of the gallery. When heroes cross, it targets up to 2 of them. Each makes a Speed check (Medium) to duck under. On a failure, roll 2d6 once, and each hero who failed takes it, minus armor. Heroes can avoid it by timing the swings (an Easy Intellect group roll) or by wedging it with a spear from the Barracks (a Strength check, Medium).

Loot box: Into the party stash: T1 Common box from a level 2 monster (Flooded Gallery). In the app: One-shots, then **Make box**.

Area 4: The Hall of Six Seals

Read aloud

Past the gallery, a dry stair climbs to a round chamber. The air is still and cold. On the far wall is a great bronze door with no handle and no lock. Set into the floor in front of it, in a ring, are six stone plates as wide as a shield. Each bears a carving: a moon, a bell, a lantern, a sheaf of wheat, a crown, and a star.

Scratched into the wall above the door, in a shaky hand, are words: Follow the song home.

This is the puzzle. The plates must be stepped on in the order of the lullaby: **moon, bell, lantern, wheat, crown, star**. King Aldren sealed the door this way in his last clear hour.

How It Works

- Each correct plate sinks with a soft chime, a note of the lullaby's tune.
- A wrong plate makes a harsh clang. Every sunken plate rises again, and the hidden darts in the walls fire at the hero on the wrong plate: a T1 hazard (Speed check, Medium; 1d6 damage on a failure).
- When the sixth plate sinks, the whole tune plays once through, and the bronze door swings open.

If the Players Get Stuck

Give hints one at a time, a few minutes apart:

- The chime from a correct plate sounds like the first note of something a hero has heard recently.
- An Easy Intellect check: a hero remembers a line of the song Corwin sang.
- A Medium Spirit/Luck check: a hero hears a man's voice, very faint, humming the tune from somewhere beyond the door.
- Finally, just point at the handout.

Why it matters: the players should wonder how a royal nursery song became the lock on a vault. Do not answer. Let it sit until Act 3.

Reward: a T1 box into the party stash, and behind the door a hook on the wall holding the king's riding cloak, torn and gray with ash.

Loot box: Into the party stash: T1 Common box from a level 2 monster (Hall of Six Seals). In the app: One-shots, then **Make box**.

Area 5: Shrine Spring

Read aloud

A small chapel opens off the passage. Clear water bubbles from a carved stone basin, and it is the first clean thing you have seen in this place. Candle stubs ring an old altar. Someone has knelt here recently and left a wax seal pressed into the stone: the royal crest.

Rest: each hero can drink once and heal to full HP. The party can rest here in safety. This is the moment to open the **party stash** in the app, split the loot from the rooms, and equip what they found. The market is closed down here (there's no merchant in a flooded crypt), so nobody sells anything.

Area 6: Captain's Post

> **Read aloud**
>
> *The passage ends at a barricade of bunks and broken shields. Behind it, a big man in a captain's cloak sits on an upturned crate, sword across his knees. Half his face is still his own, and it is crying. The other half is ash.*
>
> *"Go home," Captain Varek says. "He told me to keep everyone out. Even you. Even the boy. Especially the boy." He stands. "Please. Go home."*

Varek can be talked to, briefly. A Medium Charm check gets one answer before the rot takes him: *"He isn't gone. That's the worst part. He's still in there."* Then he attacks.

Heroes	Enemies
3	Captain Varek
4	Captain Varek, Hollow Recruit

Captain Varek

Level 2 Boss • Uncommon • Common tier

Stats	Constitution 1, Strength 2, Speed 1, Spirit/Luck 1
HP	45
Armor	0
Initiative	d20 + 1
Actions	1
Melee	2d6 + 2 (longsword, two hands)
Ranged	2d4 (hand crossbow)

Abilities

Shield Bash (signature, T1, Strength): 1d6 + 2 damage to one target and knock them Prone for 1 round.
Last Oath (T1, Constitution): Gain 1d6 + 1 temporary HP.
Hollow Shout (T1, Charm): One target is Frightened for 1 round and cannot move toward Varek.

Loot: each hero opens a T2 box (Varek is Uncommon). On his body: the sanctum key, an iron disk stamped with a star, and a torn page from the king's journal (Appendix C). Give the players the page.

> **Loot box:** Each hero opens one T2 Uncommon box from a level 2 monster (Captain Varek). In the app: One-shots, then **Make box**.

> **Read aloud**
> *As Varek falls, the ash drains from his face. For one breath he is just a tired man. "Tell the boy," he whispers. "Tell him his father tried."*

End the session at the sanctum door, with the key in hand and the journal page read.

Act 3: The Hollow Crown

Session 3 • Level 2 to 3 • 3 to 4 hours

Scene	Time	What happens
1. The Sanctum Door	20 min	Prepare, rest, last choices
2. The Hollow King	90 min	Boss fight; Hollow Claim; a hero dies
3. The Escape	10 min	The boss flees and leaves the signet ring
4. The Scroll	30 min	Resurrection and party loot
5. Return to Brightmere	40 min	The truth, told to the prince

Scene 1: The Sanctum Door

Start with a short recap and let the heroes heal, use the party stash, and equip. When they are ready, the star key turns.

Read aloud

The door opens on a vast round chamber, a dome lit from below. At its heart, sunk into a cracked stone well, sits a soul core as big as a cart wheel. It pulses slow and dark, like a heart that has forgotten how to beat. Gray light leaks from the cracks in the floor around it.

On a stone throne before the core sits a tall figure in a full royal helm, a crown of black iron fused to its brow. Two soldiers in red flank it. As you enter, the figure rises, and the core beats faster.

It does not speak. It only raises one gray hand toward you.

Keep the helm on

The players must not learn who the Hollow King is until Scene 3. Never describe its face. If asked, the helm is closed, and the voice, when it comes, is like stone grinding.

Scene 2: The Hollow King

Heroes	Enemies
3	The Hollow King, 2 Royal Hollowguards
4	The Hollow King, 2 Royal Hollowguards

With four strong heroes, add a third Hollowguard. This is a **Deadly** fight by the threat point rules. It is meant to feel that way.

The Hollow King

Level 4 Boss • Rare • Common tier

Stats	Constitution 2, Strength 2, Intellect 3, Speed 1, Charm 1
HP	90
Armor	1
Initiative	d20 + 1
Actions	1
Movement	10
Melee	2d6 + 2 (iron scepter, two hands)
Ranged	2d4 + 3 (gray fire from an open hand)

Abilities

Hollow Claim (signature, T3, Intellect): Strikes up to 3 targets twice each. See the box below.

Royal Command (T2, Charm): Two targets are Frightened for 2 rounds and cannot move toward the king.

Crown Guard (T1, Constitution): Gain 1d6 + 2 temporary HP.

Escapes at 22 HP or less (see Scene 3). Never dies in this adventure.

Royal Hollowguard

Level 2 Minion • Common • Common tier

HP	5
Armor	0
Initiative	d20 + 0
Actions	1
Melee	2d6 (halberd)
Ranged	2d4

The Hollowguards swarm: one initiative and one pooled attack roll.

Hazard: The Core Pulse (T1)

Clue: the cracks in the floor glow brighter just before it fires. At the end of every round, the core pulses. One hero standing on the glowing cracks (CM's choice) makes a Constitution check (Medium) or takes 1d6 damage, minus armor. Heroes who stay off the cracks are safe, but the cracks spread each round, so space gets tight.

Hollow Claim: How a Hero Dies

Hollow Claim is a scripted ability. The king uses it exactly twice in the fight. The app still rolls the damage for the show, but the result is fixed: any hero struck by both strikes of one Claim drops below 1 HP, whatever their HP or armor. Gray chains of light pour from the king's hand, wrap the heroes, and pull something out of them.

The First Claim (round 2). The king targets 2 heroes (party of 3) or 3 heroes (party of 4). Each drops below 1 HP and loses a level, falling from level 2 to level 1. They lose a stat point (at random if none is unspent), and their XP bar empties. They stay in the fight at their new full HP: 5 × (1 + Constitution). Make it terrifying. The players should see that the next hit on a level 1 hero means death.

The Second Claim (when the king first drops to 45 HP or less, or at round 5, whichever comes first). The king targets every hero the first Claim missed, plus one hero it already hit. The heroes it missed before each lose a level. The hero it already hit is now a level 1 commoner, so they die.

Choosing who dies: the best choice is a player you have asked privately before the session. If you haven't, choose the hero closest to the king, or roll a die among the heroes the first Claim hit. Either way, every hero in the party is struck exactly once and one hero falls for good, so the threat is shared and the death is no one's fault.

When the hero dies, stop the fight for a breath. Let the player describe their hero's last moment. Then the king's helm turns toward the rest of the party, and the fight goes on.

Breaking the rules on purpose: monsters normally use each ability once per fight, at no more than their level ÷ 3 in tier (T2 for the king). Hollow Claim is a story ability and ignores both. The king's other abilities follow the normal rules.

Other tactics: the king uses Royal Command once, on the two heroes doing the most damage, and Crown Guard once, when he is first bloodied. On his other turns without a Claim, he throws gray fire at whoever is hurt or swings his scepter. The Hollowguards stand between the heroes and the king.

Scene 3: The Escape

When the Hollow King drops to **22 HP or less**, he flees. Do not let the heroes finish him.

Read aloud

The king staggers. The core behind him screams, a sound you feel in your teeth, and the floor around the well splits wide. Gray light swallows the throne. As the king sinks into it, a blow catches his helm, and the iron splits along its seam. Something small and gold drops out and rings against the stone.

And under the core's scream, from inside the broken helm, comes a sound you have heard before. A man's voice, cracked and soft, humming a song for a child.

Then he is gone, and the core goes dark and cold.

The gold thing is a **signet ring** with the royal crest. Every Hollowguard left standing collapses into ash.

Scene 4: The Scroll

Behind the empty throne is a small stone altar the king guarded. On it lies a sealed scroll case and a second journal page (Appendix C, page 2).

> **Read aloud**
>
> *The case is old silver, cold to the touch. Inside, a single scroll glows with a warm gold light, the first warm light you've seen in this place. Written across the top in the old tongue: Return Spark.*

Scroll of the Return Spark

Magic item • T5 Legendary • One use

Use	One action. Needs a free hand and a voice to read it aloud.
Effect	Brings back one fallen ally who died within the last 24 hours, with HP equal to a roll of 5d6 (up to their max HP).
After	The scroll burns to gold ash.

The revived hero comes back at the level they died at: level 1.

Any hero can read it. The 24-hour resurrection window from the Core Guidelines means the party can use it right away, and they should. Let the revived player describe what their hero saw on the other side, if they want to.

Party Loot

Roll **party loot** for the boss: one T3 box (the king is Rare), and every hero gets a full copy. Cores from this box are level 4 cores: with the XP bar, one fills the rest of a lower-level hero's bar, so the fallen can begin to climb back.

> **Loot box:** Party loot: every hero gets a full copy of one T3 Rare box from a level 4 monster (The Hollow King). In the app: One-shots, then **Make box**.

Scene 5: Return to Brightmere

The journey home takes a day. Let the players talk. They have a ring, two journal pages, a song, and a terrible guess.

> **Read aloud**
>
> *Brightmere's bells ring as your cart comes through the gate. Word has run ahead of you, and the whole town is in the square. Prince Corwin is on the keep steps before the cart stops, searching the faces in the back for one that isn't there.*
>
> *"Where is he?"*

Let the heroes tell him in their own words. Do not rush this. When they show him the ring, read:

Read aloud

Corwin takes the ring and turns it over and over. When he speaks, his voice is very small. "He hummed it. You said he hummed it." He looks up at you, and he is not trying to look older anymore. "Then he's still in there. He's still in there, and he's alone."

He closes his hand around the ring. "Rest. Heal. Then I need you to go back for him. Not to kill him. To bring my father home."

Ending the Adventure

- **Milestone:** Corwin opens the treasury. Every hero returns to level 2, then the CM can raise the whole party to level 3 at this milestone. Heroes rebuild lost stat points as they level.
- **Hesk's favor:** any hero who tipped Mother Hesk in Act 1 is offered a free ability token and a T1 core for a new ability.
- **Next:** the Hollow King is out there with a broken core in his chest, and somewhere inside him is a father who still remembers a song. Where he went, and whether he can be saved, is the next adventure.

Appendix A: Monster Quick Reference

Monster	Lvl	Type	HP	Armor	Melee	Ranged
Granary Rat	1	Minion	3	0	1d4	-
Corrupted Soldier	2	Standard	10	0	2d6 + 1	2d4
Hollow Recruit	2	Minion	5	0	2d6	2d4
Captain Varek	2	Boss	45	0	2d6 + 2	2d4
The Hollow King	4	Boss	90	1	2d6 + 2	2d4 + 3
Royal Hollowguard	2	Minion	5	0	2d6	2d4

All monsters are built with Chapter 9 of the Core Guidelines. In the app, pick The Hollow Crown under One-shots in the CM tab to add any fight with one tap, or enter them in the monster tab with these numbers. The Granary Rat's bite is the only override.

Hazards

Hazard	Tier	Targets	Check	On a failure
Tripwire Darts (Entry Hall)	T1	1	Speed, Medium	1d6
The Pendulum (Flooded Gallery)	T2	2	Speed, Medium	2d6
Seal Darts (wrong plate)	T1	1	Speed, Medium	1d6
Core Pulse (end of each round)	T1	1	Constitution, Medium	1d6

Appendix B: The Lullaby

Hand this page to the players in Act 1, Scene 4. The bold words are the six seals, in order.

Follow the Song Home

a Brightmere lullaby

*Hush now, little one, the **moon** is on the hill,*
*The **bell** up in the tower has gone sweet and still.*
*Your father lit the **lantern** and set it by the door,*
*The **wheat** is in the barn, love, the harvest's in the store.*
*So lay down your **crown**, now, lay it by your bed,*
*And a **star** will keep the watch while you lay down your head.*
And if you're ever lost, love, and the dark is long and wide,
just follow the song home, and I'll be there inside.

For the CM

Seal order: moon, bell, lantern, wheat, crown, star. The last two lines are not seals; they are the clue the king left for his son. In Act 3, the Hollow King hums this tune as he escapes.

Appendix C: The King's Journal

Give page 1 to the players after Captain Varek falls (Act 2). Give page 2 after the boss escapes (Act 3).

Page 1

Day 44 of Summer. We reached the vault. The core is worse than the old records said. It does not leak. It reaches.

Day 47. Three of the men have gone gray. Varek says it is the damp. I let him say it.

Day 52. I put my hand on the core to seal it, and it put its hand on me. I can hear it now when I sleep. It wants a crown to wear.

Day 55. I have locked the inner door with the boy's song. The thing in me will forget everything else, but I don't think it can forget that.

Page 2

I don't know the day. I don't know how long I have been sitting here.

If someone finds this, I have hidden the Spark on the altar. It was meant for me. I will not use it. Use it for whoever I hurt.

Tell Corwin I'm sorry. Tell him I was not afraid of the dark. I was afraid of what I would do in it.

Tell him to follow the song.